

CHAPTER 3: NEED HELP? FIND A MYTHICAL CREATURE

“Live!” Erik pleaded as he held Katria in his arms. He couldn’t let her die, but the wound was bad. He looked around. Maybe there was some stone and part of an animal he could find. If he could get his war mage ability maybe he could heal. No, that wouldn’t work. His ability wouldn’t come until he forged his weapon in the fairy fire.

“Help!” he called out, hoping for a miracle.

The miracle came, but not in the way he expected. He’d hoped maybe a fairy who could heal would come, but instead, a bright light suddenly shone from the forest. The trees and flowers around seemed to perk up, and Catria stopped bleeding.

As the bright light lessened, Erik could see the cause of it. A unicorn stood right in front of him. Of course it said no words, but it looked down at Catria and touched its horn to her.

She instantly started breathing normally, and her heart

rate picked back up.

When her eyes opened, she sat up and saw the unicorn. Their eyes met for a moment, as if something was being communicated between them.

Catria put her hand on the unicorn's nose. "Thank you. You saved my life."

The unicorn nodded its head, then rubbed it against her and flipped his mane into her face.

She cautiously reached over and touched the mane. The unicorn nodded to her.

Was he offering a hair? Catria didn't want to upset him. He'd just saved her life, but if he wanted her to have the hair, she would not turn down unicorn as her animal. She petted the mane for a moment, and again the unicorn shook the mane near her face.

She took a breath and hoped she was reading the unicorn right. She gently pulled a hair from the unicorn's mane and said, "Thank you again. This is most kind."

The unicorn then looked over at Erik and shook his mane at him.

Erik picked a hair, patted the unicorn's nose, and said, "Thank you. Thank you for everything. This hair is a great gift, but mostly, thanks for saving Catria. I only just met her, but she seems an incredible lady."

The unicorn reared up on its hind legs with a flash of light from a sparkling horn, then ran off, and a brilliant flash of light made them lose sight of it, so they had no

idea where it went.

Both Catria and Erik stared the direction the unicorn went and then looked at each other in shock.

“You’re alive!” Erik exclaimed, giving her a hug.

“Was that really a unicorn?” Catria asked. “I’m not seeing things because I was injured am I?”

“No,” Erik assured her. “I’m surprised it came with me around. I didn’t even believe unicorns were real. Honestly Fae are hard enough to believe, but since Alfir has Faeborn, I have to believe it.”

She stared up into his face. “Whatever you did to call the unicorn, thank you.”

“I didn’t do anything,” Erik corrected. “You must be some lady.”

She smiled at him, and he helped her up. “Shall we get going?” he asked. “We both have our plants and animal. We need to get our gems and leave. You wanted clear quartz, right? That shouldn’t be too hard to find. Since you saw the unicorn, do you still want clear quartz?”

“Yes,” Catria answered. “Does seeing the unicorn change what you are looking for?”

“No,” Erik answered. “I wasn’t sure what stone to pick up when I came in, and I still have no idea.”

“I’ll help you,” Catria offered eagerly. “I can’t believe I feel as well as I do. Unicorn magic is incredible. I don’t think I’ve ever felt better.”

“It’s good to see you healed and well. Shall we head across the stream?” He offered her his hand and helped her walk across stones to get to the other side.

Catria was surprised that she enjoyed having her hand in his so much. She hardly knew him, but she felt something, maybe because they had both just seen a unicorn together.

As they crossed the river and started walking along the edge of it.

They hadn’t gone far when they saw stones shimmering in the water.

“There is likely clear quartz in there,” Catria noted, so she knelt down at the edge of the stream and started looking through the rocks.

Erik didn’t kneel down and look too. Instead, he held his whip and looked around for trouble. He wasn’t going to let her get hurt again.

“Can you find a stone for me?” he asked as he watched.

“You trust me to do that?” Catria asked. “No war mage has someone from another team pick one of their items. Doesn’t that scare you?”

“No,” he assured her with no hesitation. “I trust you. You know stones better than I do. You’ll pick something good, and either way, I’m watching for trouble.”

Catria looked around. There were many stones, but she picked up a very black stone that had striations going

along it. There were some specks of either mica or quartz in it too, which gave it some sparkle. She picked it up, looked at it for a moment, stood up, and handed it to him. “If I’m right, this is black tourmaline. It’s really good protection against evil, and that should go well with the unicorn.”

He took it from her, looked at it, and responded, “Nice. I like it. Let’s go. There is no reason to stay here any longer than we need to. You already almost died once. I don’t know we can count on the unicorn again.”

“Sure. We have our items. Let’s head out,” Catria agreed.

They both headed the direction of the arch.

All was going well until Erik stopped and held his hand up to Catria to signal that she didn’t move or make a sound.

She quickly found out why. A man on his soul quest was hiding behind a tree and had an arrow ready to shoot at the two contestants from Ramere. Obviously, the bowman was from Phyrn. Catria couldn’t place which tribe, but it was obvious from the black leather and the deeply tanned skin that the man was from Phyrn.

Someone was about to die, she knew it, but what could she do?

As she tried to decide, Erik ran over and tackled the man to the ground. He did get the shot off, but due to being tackled, his aim was bad, and the people from Ramere were not harmed.

Catria panicked. What could she do? She needed to help, but Erik and the Phyrnian were grappling on the ground. If she tried to help, she might get in the way instead.

“I’ll kill you!” the Phyrnian yelled as he fought Erik.

Unfortunately, that was true. Catria knew it. Sabotage of another soul quest contestant was punishable by death, so the Phyrnian would fight to kill Erik. The thought suddenly struck. If he did, he’d try to kill her too. There could be no witnesses.

She ran over, still unsure what to do and saw the Phyrnian pull a knife. Erik grabbed his wrist, and Catria kicked him.

When she did, it distracted him enough that Erik knocked him unconscious.

“What do we do now?” Catria asked.

“Get out of here,” Erik answered. He held out his hand for her and started toward the two from Ramere.

There was a short discussion, where Erik and Catria explained what happened and pointed to the Phyrnian who was unconscious on the ground.

The two from Ramere were convinced it wasn’t Erik and Catria who tried to shoot them, and went on their way.

Only then did Catria really notice the blood running down Erik’s cheek. “Are you all right?” she panicked.

“I’m fine,” he assured her. “Honestly, I should be

much worse off than I am, as our full powers won't come until we forge our weapons, but apparently unicorn is strong."

Catria smiled. "Because you are pure enough to have seen one."

He raised his eyebrows. "You are too. Now, let's get out of here."

They could see the arch, and worried that they'd be sabotaged on their way out, but they weren't. Two war mages stood at the arch looking in, so if anyone tried anything, they were sanctioned to come in and help.

Erik and Catria stepped through the arch together. He tipped his hat, told her it had been a pleasure working with her, and led her over to her team. Everyone on it was running toward her.

She was congratulated and everyone wanted to hear of her adventure.

Her mother ran over and hugged her, very relieved she'd made it out safely.

As everyone excitedly talked, Catria looked over at Erik. He was with the team and other people from Cruia. Likely, some were family. She saw him hug a beautiful girl with long auburn hair. Perhaps he was courting her. That would be a little disappointing. Would she see him again? Would they have to fight each other?

So many thoughts ran through her mind until she was pulled out of them by Rhys telling her it was time for

them to go and forge her weapon in the fairy fire at the arena.

Forge her weapon... That was a daunting thought.

“What did you get?” Rhys asked.

She pulled out her items and answered, “Clear quartz, white willow, and unicorn.”

Everyone around her stopped and stared at her.

“Unicorn?” Rhys asked. “Really?”

“Yes,” Catria answered. She showed him the beautiful white strand of hair from the unicorn’s mane.”

“Hide that?” Rhys insisted. “I’m not sure what unicorn does, as no one has ever seen one before, as they are only supposed to show themselves to the purest of hearts, but their power is legendary. Hide that, and let’s hope the other teams don’t find out. It will likely make you a target.”

Catria tensed. Was her unicorn a blessing or assured death?